How the Tide Has TURNED



From a presence in a handful of sectors, women are making a mark across India Inc. This will now lead to an even larger role in the growth of coporate India. BY **KRISHNA GOPALAN**

WOMEN HOLDING TOP positions in financial services was the norm for several years, from banking to asset management, insurance, investment banking and private equity. Over the past two decades, the landscape has encompassed several other sectors, even as financial services remain an anchor point.

That is not a small achievement. It indicates a big shift in mindset and will, inevitably, lay the base for what is going to become a more widespread presence. Such has been the influx of women smarts in multiple industries that today, the bigger the problem, the more one sees women occupying pivotal positions. That would include conventional favourites such as IT or consumer, and new, traditionally male-dominated sectors such as manufacturing, automobiles, mining, among others.

This year, the ability to rough it out in the most difficult terrain has been a key takeaway. For instance, for Priya Agarwal Hebbar, Chairperson of Hindustan Zinc and Director of Vedanta, one of the tipping points in her career was the time spent in mines.

"I went down with the shift crews, stayed on site and had lunch with the teams. After the first day or so, they stopped being polite and were a lot more candid," she says. Suddenly, the conversation veered around issues like shift patterns, heat at depth, and time away from families. "Those chats changed soon on how we think about our own employee welfare and our relationship with communities around where we operated," says Hebbar.

CHANGING TIMES

Let us go deep into the shift that has taken place and what led to it. Manisha Girotra, CEO of investment bank Moelis India, recalls the initial phase when global banks and the likes of ICICI Bank took a deep interest in recruiting women. "It started with consumer banking that called for high EQ followed later by corporate and investment banking," she says. Plus,